Parshas Lech-Lecha

ב״ה

The Lamplighter

Toronto's Weekly Torah Publication

Friday, October 23, 2026 · Issue #596 · 12 Cheshvan, 5787

A project of Chabad Young Leaders

Parsha Insights

Our Lot in Life

By Chaya Shuchat

It seems like the ultimate codependent relationship.

In this week's Torah portion we are introduced to a shadowy character named Lot, Abraham's nephew. Through his relationship with Abraham, Lot grows wealthy and powerful, but that's what starts the rift between them. Abraham is always careful to muzzle his cattle when passing through the fields of others. Lot's shepherds let his animals graze wherever they please. Their argument is that G-d has promised to give the land of Canaan to Abraham, and Abraham has no children, so it will all go to Lot. Therefore, they feel they are justified in letting Lot's animals loose in anyone's field.

To Abraham, this is utterly unacceptable. Although G-d has promised the land to his descendants, he has not yet taken possession, and thus has no rights to his neighbors' fields. In any case, Lot is not the ultimate heir. To make matters worse, Lot resembles Abraham physically1 so his behavior reflects negatively on Abraham as well. Finally, Abraham issues an ultimatum: "Please, let us go our separate ways. If you go to the left, I will go to the right. If you go to the right, I will go to the left."



For Lot, this should have been an opportunity for self-reflection—to improve his ways and not lose his relationship with his revered Uncle Abraham. Instead, Lot agrees to part and sets up house among the most depraved people then in existence—the residents of Sodom.

Not long afterward, four strong kings pick a battle with five weak kings, including the king of Sodom, and subdue the population. After 12 years of subjugation, the five kings rebel. War breaks out, and Lot is taken prisoner. When Abraham hears the news, he immediately swings into action and personally goes into battle to rescue Lot.

At this point, does Lot gratefully, meekly return to Abraham's court? He does not. He continues living with the corrupt Sodomites and even becomes a leader among them.

Eventually, matters come to a head, and the evil of Sodom reaches the heavens. G-d comes to a verdict: The city of Sodom must be destroyed. G-d shares the news with his trusted servant Abraham, who proceeds to pray on behalf of the people of Sodom. He is unable to find a quorum of righteous people in whose merit the city should be saved. But Lot, at least, is spared the calamity.

When the angels appear to rescue Lot, though, he is none too eager to join them. The angels drag him away, and he escapes with his life only moments before the city is destroyed.

The final straw is when Lot's daughters awaken to the destruction around them and assume that they are the only ones left. They get their father drunk and become pregnant from him. News soon spreads of Lot's incestuous relationship with his daughters, and Abraham is forced to move away in shame.

The common thread in this saga is that Abraham is repeatedly disappointed and humiliated by the behavior of his nephew, yet he bails him out time and again.

Abraham was a leader—a highly motivational person—and it must have pained him greatly not to be able to exert more influence on his nephew. But Lot was his own person who made his own decisions. Why did Abraham not simply let him live with the consequences? Why did Abraham not make a clean break from Lot? Why did he keep swooping in to save Lot from himself? Was it classic codependency, or was there another dynamic at play?

Perhaps Abraham saw potential in Lot and kept trying to bring it to the fore.

Chassidic teachings explain that Lot represents the part of the mind that is uncouth,

Continued on next page

What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

Candle Lighting Times

Greater Toronto Area

Light Candles	6:03 PM
Shabbos Ends	7:03 PM

Parsha in a Nutshell

Parshas Lech-Lecha

The name of the Parshah, "Lech Lecha," means "Go Forth" and it is found in Genesis 12:1.

G-d speaks to Abram, commanding him, "Go from your land, from your birthplace and from your father's house, to the land which I will show you." There, G-d says, he will be made into a great nation. Abram and his wife, Sarai, accompanied by his nephew Lot, journey to the land of Canaan, where Abram builds an altar and continues to spread the message of a one G-d.

A famine forces the first Jew to depart for Egypt, where beautiful Sarai is taken to Pharaoh's palace; Abram escapes death because they present themselves as brother and sister. A plague prevents the Egyptian king from touching her, and convinces him to return her to Abram and to compensate the brother-revealed-as-husband with gold, silver and cattle.

Back in the land of Canaan, Lot separates from Abram and settles in the evil city of Sodom, where he falls captive when the mighty armies of Chedorlaomer and his three allies conquer the five cities of the Sodom Valley. Abram sets out with a small band to rescue his nephew, defeats the four kings, and is blessed by Malki-Zedek the king of Salem (Jerusalem).

G-d seals the Covenant Between the Parts with Abram, in which the exile and persecution (galut) of the people of Israel is foretold, and the Holy Land is bequeathed to them as their eternal heritage.

Still childless ten years after their arrival in the Land, Sarai tells Abram to marry her maidservant Hagar. Hagar conceives, becomes insolent toward her mistress, and then flees when Sarai treats her harshly; an angel convinces her to return, and tells her that her son will father a populous nation. Ishmael is born in Abram's eighty-sixth year.

Thirteen years later, G-d changes Abram's name to Abraham ("father of multitudes"), and Sarai's to Sarah ("princess"), and promises that a son will be born to them; from this child, whom they should call Isaac ("will laugh"), will stem the great nation with which G-d will establish His special bond. Abraham is commanded to circumcise himself and his descendants as a "sign of the covenant between Me and you." Abraham immediately complies, circumcising himself and all the males of his household.

Continued from previous page

unrefined. It's the part that behaves unpredictably, sometimes shamefully; the part that gets us into scrapes time and again; the part that can drag us to the most desolate, degraded places—our personal Sodom. We try to distance ourselves, but can never quite escape from our Lot. And perhaps, on some level, we don't want to.

And this is something that Abraham bequeathed to us, his descendants: We will never give up on our Lot, whether it's a wayward child, an annoying neighbor—or ourselves. We don't give up because even the most unrefined and embarrassing person has potential waiting to be discovered.

Lot's two daughters produced two sons, who grew into two mighty nations, Moab and Ammon. From Moab descended Ruth, the famous convert who became the great-grandmother of King David. From Ammon descended Naamah, wife of King Solomon, and mother of his firstborn son and heir, Rehoboam. Thus, the lineage of the dynasty of David, and by extension Moshiach, comes through Lot.

Abraham foresaw that Lot would be a forebear of King David and Moshiach. On the verse in Psalms, "I have found my servant David," the Midrash comments, "Where did He find him? In Sodom!"

The legacy of Lot is that no circumstance in life is so low or so depraved that no good can come from it. Abraham's rescue of Lot empowers us to rescue ourselves and each other from the pits of Sodom—as many times as it takes—until we've refined our Lot to the utmost, and the world is finally ready for Moshiach.

Jewish Matters

More Than a Menu

Kosher is the set of Jewish dietary laws that govern what and how Jews eat. They come from the Torah and are observed first and foremost because they are a divine commandment.

Only certain animals are permitted. Mammals must both have split hooves and chew their cud, so cows, sheep, goats, and deer are kosher, while pigs, rabbits, and horses are not. Domestic birds like chicken, duck, and turkey are kosher. Fish must have fins and scales, so salmon and tuna are kosher, while shellfish, catfish, and swordfish are not. Reptiles and insects are generally forbidden. Eggs and milk are kosher only if they come from kosher animals, and honey is permitted.

Meat must come from an animal slaughtered by a trained person called a shochet, using a swift, painless cut with a perfectly smooth knife. All blood must then be removed, through soaking and salting. Meat and dairy are never cooked or eaten together, so separate utensils, dishes, and surfaces are used, and a waiting period is observed between eating them. Foods that are neither meat nor dairy, such as eggs, fruits, vegetables, and grains, are called pareve and can be eaten with either. Fish is also pareve, though it is not eaten with meat. Fruits and vegetables must be checked for insects, and wine and grape juice must be certified kosher.

Because even a small trace of non-kosher food can make a dish non-kosher, and hot utensils transfer "taste," a kosher kitchen must keep its cookware and surfaces carefully separated. Processed foods and restaurants therefore need certification from a reliable rabbi or kosher supervision agency, shown by a symbol on the package or at the establishment.

Beyond the commandment itself, many see kosher as a way to bring holiness into everyday life, turning the ordinary act of eating into something done with awareness and purpose.

Food For Thought

Each generation has its role in history.

From all the generations before us we inherited a wealth of dreams: philosophy, truths, wisdom and purpose. We are tiny dwarfs standing on the shoulders of their ideas and their noble deeds.

Our generation's mandate—and destiny—is to make the dream real.

Your thoughts on the Lamplighter matter!
Tell us what you like and how we can improve it.

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

The Wonder Fruit

By Elazar Gorelik

My Story - with the - Rebbe



My family fled the Soviet Union right after World War Two ended and wandered around Europe until 1948 when the State of Israel was founded. At that time, my parents – together with another thirty-four families – responded to the Previous Rebbe's call to establish a Chabad village in Israel.

In the beginning, Kfar Chabad was an agricultural settlement and like most of the residents, my father – Rabbi Avraham Shmuel Gorelik – also worked in agriculture. But, in 1956, he decided to enter a partnership with Rabbi Nachman Elbaum, a dealer in etrogim, the fruits of citron trees which are necessary for Sukkot rituals.

Rabbi Elbaum brought seedlings from Calabria, Italy, and with these my father started the first etrog orchard in Israel. For generations, the preferred etrogim came from Italy, but there were concerns – because etrogim are notoriously difficult to grow, very delicate and fragile – that the farmers in Italy were grafting etrog branches onto other citrus trees. Therefore, the Rebbe had instructed that seeds from Calabrian etrogim that had not been grafted be sent to Israel and that we begin growing them here.

From its inception the Rebbe showed great interest in my father's etrog orchard. In a letter to the Kfar Chabad community board, dated November 12, 1959, the Rebbe wrote: "I have received the happy news that several hundred etrogim have grown in Kfar Chabad [from seedlings] originating in Calabria, as the true 'beautiful fruit' specified in the Torah refers to the Calabrian etrogim."

He also expressed concern that these young trees be properly protected from the elements with fences and buffer zones, adding, "Surely those who are involved in this will look into the matter soon." After reiterating how happy he was to have learned of this development, he expressed surprise that the good tidings had not been shared with him immediately.

In 1960, the first usable fruits were picked from the trees to everyone's great joy.

A few years later Rabbi Elbaum left Israel, and my father bought out his share of the partnership, continuing on his own with the assistance of my brother in-law, Rabbi Moshe Naparstek. But immediately he faced a challenge. In the late 1960s, many orchards in Israel were afflicted by a plant disease called "citrus blight," some even having to be totally uprooted. There was no treatment for this disease and my father was very worried that our orchard would be afflicted as well; he even debated whether it was a good idea to continue to grow etrogim at all.

But when, in 1969, I traveled to New York for the High Holidays, the Rebbe totally negated my father's concerns. "Your father's land is very suitable for growing etrogim. Clearly, this disease can be overcome since others are still planting in Israel, and Jews need to make a blessing on kosher etrogim."

The Rebbe also pointed out that, lately, it was becoming difficult to bring kosher etrogim from Italy, because grafting has become more common there and it is hard to supervise their orchards. So, he said, "ultimately, everyone will come to depend on your father's orchard."

With regard to the citrus blight, the Rebbe suggested we contact the Israeli Ministry of Agriculture and request that they find a solution since Jews must have kosher etrogim. He also added that if this will incur expenses, we should inform his secretariat and he would contribute toward the costs.

We did contact the Ministry of Agriculture as the Rebbe advised, and they found some solution which – though it didn't entirely prevent the disease – minimized the risk through special covers and sprays. And this saved our orchard.

After some years, it became too difficult for my father to care for the orchard, and I began to think that I should abandon my career in education and take over for him. But the Rebbe did not support this idea. He told me, in an audience in 1976: "From what I hear you are successful in education, and the situation in Israel today is such that one who is successful in education may not leave. You should hire someone to take care of the orchard; then you will only need to supervise him." So that is what I did, and thank G-d, the orchard continued to flourish.

Throughout the years, every time I would come to see the Rebbe, he would be interested in hearing the details about the etrogim, and he would give me all sorts of instructions regarding the orchard and even about marketing. At some point we bought more land in order to expand the orchard, but we were forced to buy a plot that was bigger than we needed. So we debated whether to plant only etrogim, which are a big investment, or whether to plant half etrogim and half other crops. The Rebbe's response left us with no doubt: "It is a wonder that such a thought entered your mind – you must plant [etrogim] to the maximum capacity!" And then he reiterated what he said earlier, "There will come a day when it will be difficult to bring kosher etrogim from Italy and everyone will rely on your orchard."

We followed the Rebbe's advice. Also, a few times after Sukkot, we asked the Rebbe for his etrog so we could take the seeds and plant them. That way, Chabad chasidim in Israel would be able to make the blessing on an etrog grown from the seeds of an etrog which the Rebbe had used. It would mean a lot to them to be able to do that.

But we never received a response to our request, until 1990. That year – this was at the end of the Hebrew month of Tishrei of 5751, the year that the Rebbe dubbed "the year of wonders" – he sent us two of his etrogim.

When they arrived, we took them to Rabbi Mordechai Ashkenazi, the rabbi of Kfar Chabad, to open them in his presence. We extracted fifty-four seeds and planted them right away.

Twenty-six seedlings grew from these seeds, and of those, we selected the best ones and planted an entire orchard with them. We uprooted the former orchard started with the seedlings from Italy, so that people would know for certain that their etrog came from the Rebbe's own.

At first only Chabad chasidim were interested in these special etrogim, but later on, we discovered that there is a great demand among the general public, from all streams of Judaism, and therefore, as time went on, all our orchards were planted with seeds from the fruits of these trees.

We called the fruits of these orchard Esrogei Arenu Niflaos – "Citrons of the Year of Wonders,"and today they are available for purchase around the world.

———————

Rabbi Elazar Gorelik lives in Kfar Chabad where he formerly taught at the Kfar Chabad vocational school. He was interviewed in May of 2014

Did You Just Change the Course of History?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

Question:

I try to make Friday night dinner a special family occasion, but frankly, it's a lot of work. Getting everyone together, preparing the food, setting the table, making Kiddush. And half the time the kids are fighting or complaining. Sometimes I wonder if I'm really achieving anything by making Shabbos dinner. Help?

Response:

You have no idea how huge an impact your Shabbos dinners are having. You are making history and fixing the world. And feeding your family too.

Shabbos dinner is a cosmic event, a journey from Creation to the coming of Moshiach. Each element adds another dimension and conveys a deep message.

We start with Kiddush , recalling how G-d created the world in six days and rested on the seventh. The universe has a Creator, and He made it for a purpose.

Then we drink the wine, correcting the very first human mistake. Adam and Eve ate the forbidden fruit, which according to one opinion in the Talmud was a grape. They used the fruit for something forbidden. We use it for a mitzvah.

Next we wash our hands , taking us to Noah's Flood. The world had become so corrupt that it needed to be washed clean. But instead of waiting for a flood to purify us, we wash our own hands. We can clean up our own mess.

Then comes the challah dipped in salt . This reminds us of Sodom, a society so selfish that people wouldn't even share salt with a neighbour. We do the opposite. We put salt on our bread and share it generously with family, friends and guests. Where Sodom shut people out, our Shabbos table welcomes them in.

Not bad. We fixed the sin of Adam and Eve, the generation of the Flood and Sodom, and we haven't even reached the first course.

So then comes the meal itself . We enter the world of food, appetite and pleasure, just as our ancestors descended into Egypt, where they became slaves. And we too can become slaves to our physical desires. But when we enjoy our food with gratitude and holiness, rather than being controlled by the material world, we elevate it. That's our own little Exodus.

During the meal we share words of Torah , bringing us to Mount Sinai. A thought on the parsha, a question, a story or a lively debate. The same Torah given thousands of years ago comes alive again at our table.

Finally, Birkat Hamazon , Grace After Meals, takes us into the future. We pray for Jerusalem to be rebuilt, for the return of the Temple and for the coming of Moshiach, when the world will finally fulfil its purpose.

And so, in the space of one meal, we have travelled from Creation to Redemption. From Noach to Sodom, from Egypt to Sinai, from the beginning of history to its climax.

But how do we get there? What moves the world from its messy beginnings to its ultimate glorious destination?

It's what happens around your table.

The conversations with your kids. The guests you welcome. The Torah you share. The Jewish memories you create. The stories you tell. The values you pass on.

We think of history as something that happens on a grand stage. But the real stage is our dining room. Even if the kids are fighting and the soup is spilling, you're still creating a Jewish home, passing on a tradition and building the future.

Don't give up your Shabbos dinners. The work is worth it. You are making history over a bowl of chicken soup.

Living Moshiach

"He believed in G-d, and He accounted it to him as tzedakah (righteousness)." (Lech Lecha 15:6)

The commentary Hadar Zekeinim explains that G-d regarded Abraham's faith as tzedakah, meritorious righteousness. It follows that the prophet's words, "Zion shall be redeemed by justice and her repatriates by tzedakah" (Isaiah 1:27), and many similar verses, refer not only to charity but also to faith. Israel's complete emunah, and their trust that all the prophets' promises will be fulfilled, is itself tzedakah. G-d values that faith, and in His great compassion He will bring about what He promised in its merit.

"Israel was redeemed from Egypt as a reward for their emunah" (Mechilta, Beshalach 14:31). Their faith expressed the very core of their Jewishness, the bond between Israel and the Almighty, and made them worthy of the Exodus.

Even in the harshest times of exile, the Jewish people were believers. Yet that belief was largely an inheritance, held by virtue of being "descendants of believers," rather than a faith deepened through their own awareness and effort. To be redeemed in their own merit, they had to turn that inherited faith and inherited bond with G-d into something truly personal.

The Messianic redemption is described in the same terms: "As in the days of your going out from the land of Egypt, I will show them wondrous things" (Micah 7:15). Just as Israel was redeemed from Egypt for their faith, so too will Moshiach redeem us by virtue of ours. The Midrash (Shocher Tov, ch. 40) adds that Israel merits redemption through kivuy, hopeful awaiting. By holding firm to the promise "My salvation is near to come" (Isaiah 56:1), we will merit the complete and ultimate redemption, speedily, in our very own days.

The Lamplighter

The Lamplighter publication is brought to you by The Chabad Young Leaders program under the auspices of Yeshivas Lubavitch Toronto.

This publication contains words from sacred literature. Please treat it with respect and do not deface or discard.

The Lamplighter is inspired by the works of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

Contact us at: Office@CylToronto.com
416.787.6631
3055 Bathurst St, Toronto ON.
LubavitchYeshiva.com

Much of this content is reprinted with permission from Chabad.org.

The Lamplighter is generously sponsored by Roman & Suzy Goldstein